STACK OVERFLOW DEVELOPER SURVEY • 2026

# Adoption without confidence?

Daily use can coexist with dislike.

## 54%

of current users who felt **very unfavorable** toward AI reported using it daily.

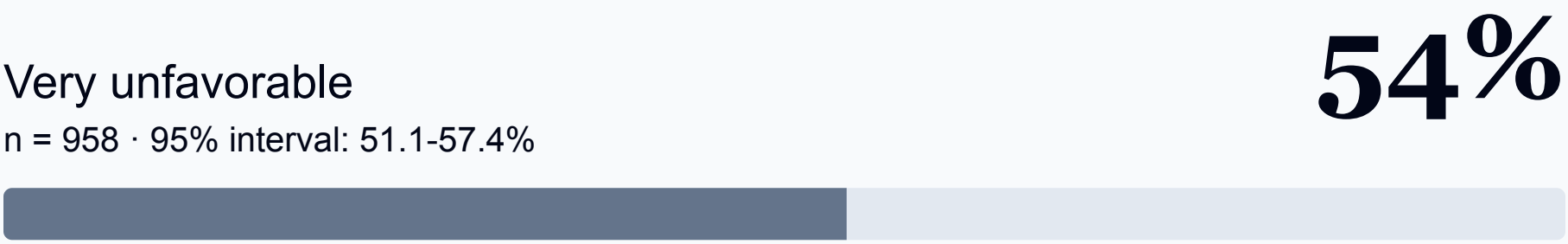
**Josh Penzell**
Imagination Applied Open Research Series

520 of 958 very unfavorable respondents in the complete-case analysis.
Self-reported daily use on at least one of four AI tool types.

THE CENTRAL FINDING

# Frequent use does not tell you how someone feels.

Share reporting daily AI use within each attitude group, 2026.




A majority of the very unfavorable group used AI daily. A substantial attitude gap still remained.

2026 current-user analysis: n = 14,158 with complete use, stance and trust data.
Daily = at least one of four AI tool types. Wilson 95% intervals shown.

# A different pattern. A different survey.

Daily-use percentages in the two survey samples:

2025

**19% / 88%**

Very unfavorable / very favorable

n = 585 / 7,408
Single development-use question

2026

**54% / 93%**

Very unfavorable / very favorable

n = 958 / 4,512
Daily on any of four tool types

**These are not like-for-like trend estimates.**
Use, attitude and trust questions changed in 2026. Separate samples were collected each year; respondents are not tracked over time. The data cannot isolate how much of the difference reflects changed behavior.

Complete-case current users: 26,102 in 2025; 14,158 in 2026.
Percentages describe each year under its own measures.

PREDICTIVE COMPARISON • 2026

# Attitude carried more signal than the trust item.

How well the study models distinguished daily from less frequent use. Higher AUC means better discrimination; 0.5 is chance.

| | |
|---|---|
| Attitude only | 0.722 |
| Trust only | 0.657 |
| Job context + attitude | 0.761 |
| Job context + trust | 0.713 |

The context-plus-attitude model outperformed context-plus-trust in all 50 matched resamples. These resamples test stability within this survey; they are not 50 independent studies.

Five-fold cross-validated ROC AUC, 2026 complete-case current users.
Models classify reported daily use; this does not show what causes it.

TRUST • 2026

# Trust often came with conditions.

What current AI users said they trust AI outputs for:

| | |
|---|---|
| 48% | When I can easily verify the output |
| 16% | Many tasks, but not important work decisions |
| 16% | Low-risk work tasks only |
| 12% | Not for most work tasks |
| 7% | Many tasks, including important work decisions |

Condensed response labels. Remaining 0.5%: not sure / do not use AI tools. Rounded percentages may not total 100%.

Current users with valid frequency and trust answers: n = 14,179.
This item differs from the accuracy-trust scale used in 2025.

ORGANIZATIONAL POLICY • 2026

# Daily use was higher where it was measured.

Among current users with a very unfavorable attitude toward AI:

AI use is optional

n = 203 · 95% interval: 39.1-52.7%

46%



AI use measured in performance

n = 142 · 95% interval: 59.5-74.8%

68%



This is an association. It does not establish that performance measurement caused more use or changed how people felt.

Very unfavorable current users with a reported organizational policy.
Wilson 95% intervals shown. Other policy categories omitted here.

READING THE EVIDENCE

# What the survey can tell us.

A useful warning about interpreting adoption metrics, with limits.

**Observed:**
Some respondents reported frequent use and a negative attitude at the same time. Attitude and trust provided different predictive signals.

**Not established:**
Whether attitude causes use, whether policy improves work, or whether the same people became more skeptical over time.

**Keep the population in view.**
This is a voluntary survey, not a representative sample of all developers or all workers. Use, attitude and trust are self-reported.

FOR AN AI ROLLOUT

# Track use.
# Ask what use means.

Frequency is one measure. Add questions about experience, reliance and results.

1

### Attitude

How do people feel about using these tools in their actual work?

2

### Reliance and verification

Which tasks will they trust AI with? What do they check before using its output?

3

### Work outcomes

Does the workflow improve quality, judgment or useful output? Measure that separately.

Practical recommendations from the findings, not tested interventions.
A usage count alone cannot answer these questions.

ADOPTION WITHOUT CONFIDENCE?

# Count the use. Understand the user.

Daily AI use can coexist with skepticism. Ask about both.

**Study and analysis code**

github.com/jpenzell/ai-adoption-paradox

**Original survey and data**

survey.stackoverflow.co/2026/ai

github.com/StackExchange/Survey

**Josh Penzell**

Imagination Applied Open Research Series

2025 and 2026 survey analysis • November 2026

Data: Stack Overflow Developer Survey, ODbL 1.0.
Analysis is independent of Stack Overflow.